

Progress Is a Colour, Not a Number

The product warms as a founder moves, and lime appears only on what has been earned. Underneath the design rule is a hard distinction every founder has to make about their own status.



FROM THE BOOK

“Progress is a colour, not a number. Lime appears only on what has been earned.”

StartPad Brand Presentation, GrowthLabs Group, 2026 · Chapter 06 · The world it creates, product

Nothing has to be labelled 47% complete.

The book describes an interface that warms as a founder moves through the missions, so the screen has already said how far they have come before any number appears. The design decision rests on a rule that is not about design at all: a status is either earned or it is asserted, and the two must not look the same.



Fifteen positions, one sweep. Position on the spectrum is the meaning — nobody has to design fifteen icons and nobody has to invent fifteen meanings. A founder seven missions in sees a warmer screen than one who is two missions in, without either being scored.

Why a percentage lies

A completion percentage averages things that are not comparable. Ninety per cent of a fundraise is not ninety per cent of the money; it is usually nothing. The number feels precise and carries almost no information, which is a bad combination in a document somebody is using to make a decision about you.

The test is who conferred it.

A status is earned when somebody other than you conferred it, and claimed when you did. That is the whole distinction and it survives every attempt to blur it. Most founder status language sits on the claimed side while sounding like the earned side, which is why experienced readers discount it automatically.

EARNED — SOMEBODY ELSE CONFERRED IT

Eleven people paid

Accepted into the cohort, March

Six customers renewed

A supplier signed the agreement

The pilot was extended by the client

CLAIMED — YOU CONFERRED IT

We have product-market fit

We are launch ready

We have strong traction

We are the leading platform for this

Our MVP is live

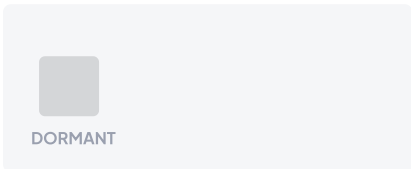
Every item on the right may be true. None of them was conferred by anybody, which is why a reader converts them back into the question “according to whom?” before deciding anything.

The one-word test

Put “according to whom?” after each status line in your deck or update. If the honest answer is “us”, it is a claim. Keep it if you want, but do not let it sit in the same visual weight as something a customer or a committee conferred.

Dormant, in motion, resolved.

The book gives the mission system three states rather than a continuous bar, and each is drawn by a rule. The reason a founder should care is that three states are honest where a percentage is not: a thing is untouched, or it is being worked on, or it is done and evidenced. There is no fourth condition, and there is certainly no seventy per cent.



Nothing has been earned yet and the status says so. Untouched is a legitimate state and does not need dressing up.



Work is happening and is visible from outside. Movement is shown by the work, not by an announcement.



Finished and evidenced. The only state that gets to be still — and the only one that earns lime.

The book's rule: dormant is held back at low opacity, in motion is cropped hard so the crop shows the movement, and resolved is solid, whole and centred.

Three states, no fourth. A founder's own plan reads more honestly on this scale than on any percentage, and it is considerably harder to flatter yourself with.

STATE	WHAT YOU MAY SAY ABOUT IT	WHAT YOU MAY NOT
Dormant	We have not started this.	It's on the roadmap. It's coming.
In motion	We are doing this now; here is what exists so far.	It's nearly done. We're in the final stages.
Resolved	This is done, and here is the evidence, dated.	Anything, without the evidence attached.

Most updates improve by getting shorter and colder.

Worksheet · Restate your status

TWENTY MINUTES

Take the status section of your most recent deck, update or application and put every line into one of three columns.

Resolved — done, with the evidence and its date

If you cannot attach the evidence, it is not resolved; move it up a row.

In motion — being worked on, with what exists so far

Dormant — not started, and honestly labelled

Naming these plainly costs you nothing and buys the other two rows their credibility.

Lines that survived none of the three columns

These were claims. Delete them or find who conferred them.

What the dormant column does for you

Counter-intuitively it is the row that makes the update believable. A founder who lists four things they have not started is read as somebody reporting rather than selling, and the resolved column is then taken at face value instead of being discounted.

The restraint at the end of it

The book's closing rule on the credential is that a document which has to be believed is not decorated — no pattern, no gradient, and no line beyond the mark. The founder equivalent is that the strongest status document you will ever send is the plainest one. If it needs design work to be convincing, the problem is not the design.

Sealed and timestamped, 14 March.

CHAPTER 05 · THE VOICE, SAY / NEVER SAY

The evidence this report asks you to attach to the resolved column is produced by **Toolkits 02 to 04** and assembled by **Toolkit 05 — The Application File**.



StartPad tells you the truth about whether you are ready, gets you ready, and gives you the proof.

What it is

A founder-readiness platform for Egypt and the wider MENA region. It takes a young person who has an idea and no company, moves them through fifteen structured missions, and turns them into someone the ecosystem will take seriously — then issues verifiable proof of that.

It is not a course platform, not an education brand and not a youth club. Nothing here is graded. Every mission ends in an artefact you own.

Three moves, always in this order

TRUTH **Where you actually stand**

Measured against what programmes actually ask for, stated plainly, before any encouragement.

READINESS **Fifteen structured missions**

They close the specific gaps the assessment found, in the order that matters. A route, not a curriculum.

PROOF **A verifiable credential**

The ecosystem can check it without asking you. You apply with a file, not a hope.

On your idea

StartPad earns when a founder gets into somewhere — an accelerator, a programme, a room. Taking a founder's idea would end that. Work submitted to a mission is sealed and timestamped to the person who submitted it, and the seal is the product.

Nothing in this document asks you to give anything up to use it. It is yours to fill in, print, and hand to whoever needs to see it.

startpad.me

Start with the readiness assessment. It is free and it takes about twenty minutes.